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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Walgreens to be sold for \$10 billion



Private-equity firm acquires giant; HQ to stay in Chicago

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Walgreens Boots Alliance is being acquired by a private-equity firm for about \$10 billion, the retail pharmacy giant announced Thursday.

An entity affiliated with Sycamore Partners will acquire Deerfield-based Walgreens in a deal that will take the company private.

Sycamore is a New York-based private-equity firm specializing in retail, consumer and distribution-related investments.

The company will continue to operate under the names Walgreens and Boots, and its headquarters will remain in the Chicago area, according to a news release. The deal is expected to close in the fourth quarter, pending shareholder and regulatory

approval.

“While we are making progress against our ambitious turnaround strategy, meaningful value creation will take time, focus and change that is better managed as a private company,” Walgreens CEO Tim Wentworth said in the news release. “Sycamore will provide us with the expertise and experience

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People and vehicles pass outside a Walgreens on Thursday near the intersection of West Division and North Dearborn streets in Chicago. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Tariffs for Mexico, Canada on hold

Trump changes tack for second time since unveiling import tax

By Christopher Rugaber
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump on Thursday postponed 25% tariffs on many imports from Mexico and some imports from Canada for a month amid widespread fears of the economic fallout from a broader trade war.

The move came a day after he granted a 30-day reprieve to automakers, who had complained to the president that his sweeping 25% tariffs would cause severe damage to U.S. carmakers.

The White House insists its tariffs are about stopping the smuggling of fentanyl, but the taxes proposed by Trump have caused a gaping wound in the decades-old North American trade partnership. Trump’s tariff plans have also caused the stock market to sink and alarmed U.S. consumers.

In addition to his claims about fentanyl, Trump has insisted that the tariffs could be resolved by fixing the trade deficit and he emphasized while speaking in the Oval Office that he still plans to impose “reciprocal” tariffs starting on April 2.

“Most of the tariffs go on April the second,” Trump said before signing the orders. “Right now, we have some temporary ones and small ones, relatively small, although it’s a lot of money having to do with Mexico and Canada.”

Trump said he was not looking to extend the exemption on the 25% tariff for autos for another month.

Imports from Mexico that comply with the 2020 USMCA trade pact would be excluded from the 25% tariffs for a month, according to the orders signed by Trump. Auto-related imports from Canada that comply with the trade deal

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Phantasha Gray holds her 10-day-old baby, Aahsaunn, in her Grayslake apartment on Thursday. Gray is a part-time bus driver who relies on Medicaid for medical care. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Illinois patients, hospitals fear potential Medicaid cuts

More than 3.4M in state are on program; many anxiously watching Washington

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

If Alex Outlaw doesn’t get monthly infusions of medication for Crohn’s disease, he experiences painful symptoms that can make it difficult to hold down a job.

But he doesn’t make enough money as a manager at a rental car agency to pay for private health insurance or to cover those infusions, which can cost more than \$1,000 each.

That’s where Medicaid comes

in. The state- and federally funded health insurance program covers Outlaw’s monthly infusions, allowing him to manage his condition so he can work and support his family of five, he said.

“It’s pretty much saving my life right now,” said Outlaw, 38, who lives on the city’s West Side. If something happened to Outlaw’s Medicaid coverage, “it’s the end for me,” he said.

Outlaw is one of more than 3.4 million people in Illinois on Medicaid — more than one-quarter of the state’s population —

who are anxiously watching discussions in Washington, D.C., over the future of the program. In late February, House Republicans passed a budget resolution instructing the committee that oversees Medicaid to cut \$880 billion in costs over the next 10 years to help pay for new and existing tax cuts and enhanced border and national security, according to House Republicans.

Lawmakers have not yet said they plan to slash Medicaid, but it would not be possible to cut that much money without reducing

Medicaid funding, according to figures released this week by the Congressional Budget Office. President Donald Trump has said he won’t cut Medicaid but has praised the budget resolution.

In the meantime, Illinois patients say they’re worried about losing their health coverage; Illinois hospitals that serve low-income areas say they may have to close or cut services depending on the depths of any cuts; and health care advocates

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Victims warn of rampant credit card scam

Con artists use sad story to lure victims into paying thousands

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

Eliazar Rodriguez was running errands in Roscoe Village when he was stopped by two men with a laminated flyer outside a Starbucks. They said they were raising money for their little brother who was killed in a drive-by shooting and told Rodriguez that they were struggling to gather funeral funds.

“I said, ‘I know what it’s like to struggle, so I’m more than happy to help with what I have,’” Rodri-

guez said.

He gave the men \$15 through Apple Pay and wrote his name down on a sheet pledging his donation. One of the guys took Rodriguez’s phone to make the transaction, showed him the screen to confirm that Rodriguez donated \$15 and the two men went on their way.

Next thing Rodriguez knew, he got an instant notification from his bank telling him he had a \$3,000 charge for a carpet purchase.

“I was just blinded by my naivety and my wanting to do good and be kind to others, only to be kind of slapped in the face,”

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Eliazar Rodriguez stands on North Lincoln Avenue in Chicago near where he was the victim of a scam. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

INSIDE

The next step in rise of flag football

Benedictine and Rockford are set to make history at Halas Hall in Illinois’ first women’s college flag football game. **Chicago Sports**

‘It’s more urgent now’

Since President Donald Trump has taken office, protests have taken over Chicago. A look at what to know. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Milestone in therapy

A clinic in Willow Springs is one of the first places in the country to offer a new device to spinal cord injury patients. **Business**

